Little Footsteps

By Ted Tally

BEN: *(while painting)* It's not that I don't like kids. Hey, I do! I'm walking in the park and I see some dad scraping bubblegum off his little girl's shoe - it just tears me up inside. You know what I mean? *(Pause)* The thing is, though - I like kids in the ***abstract***. But when I have a kid, he won't ***live*** in the abstract. He'll ***live*** in my apartment. Right here. Which, let's face it, is already crammed with one husband, one wife, and eight years' worth of furniture. So we're not just talking about the cosmic wonder of creation here. We're dealing with a Manhattan real estate problem.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Joanie is an insecure aspiring artist.*
ACTRESS: *Her husband, Ben - a witty but emotionally stunted television promoter.*
ACTOR: *In this selection, we find them converting a room in their apartment into a nursery . . .*
ACTRESS: *and coming to the realization that parenthood is no more than . . .*
ACTOR: *"The Unprepared attempting the Impossible for the sake of the Ungrateful"*
TOGETHER: *Little Footsteps by Ted Tally*

[Ben and Joanie are painting what used to be their dining room to make a nursery for the new baby] (Sound of a door opening, off and JOANIE's voice)

JOANIE: *(Off)* Ben? I'm back! Hi, honey! God, I missed you! *(She hurries to him happily, gives him a big hug) (He returns her hug cautiously, and after a moment she separates from him, looking down at his boxer shorts)* What are you *wearing?*

BEN: My underwear. I couldn't find anything to wear! And I didn't want to mess up my good clothes.

JOANIE: *(Looking around)* You sure haven't done much painting in here. What've you

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been up to? God, we're so far *behind* now . . . *(Pause. Then, more cheerfully)* Well, never mind . . . we'll do it together. *(She kisses him. He turns his face, taking the kiss on his cheek)* That'll be more fun anyway! *(She takes him by the wrists)* Feel. Put your hands right here.

BEN: Aw, I've got paint all over-

JOANIE: Never *mind!* Just feel . . . *(She places his palms flat against her belly, holds them there. A long silence while they look at one another. He feels her gently, looks down at her bulk)*

BEN: *(Quietly, with wonder)* It's so solid. So *dense.*

JOANIE: That's us, Ben. A part of *us.*

BEN: *(Ben kneels, putting his ear against her belly)* He's running another marathon. Can you tell? Go, kid, go! There's the finish line! Just one guy left to beat! *(He glances up at JOANIE, grins)* "Fetus, don't fail me now!"

JOANIE: Ben. *(But she can't help being amused. Partly to hide this, she kneels at her sketch pad. He rises, circles her)*

BEN: What's it *like* in there? . . . I mean, for one thing, we know it's *cramped.*

JOANIE: Not to her, it's not. You're just projecting.

BEN: It's *hot* as hell too, and you've got all this water gooshing around. Gooosh . . . goooooossshhh! *(He kneels behind her, pushing against her playfully, trying to distract her from her work)* So I'm floating in here . . . sort of snorkeling . . . and I've got these spooky *sounds* coming at me. And I can't get away from them! I'm trapped! Ba-da-BOOM! What was *that?* Ba-daBOOM! It's Mama's heartbeat, right in my ear! *(JOANIE smiles)* And-what's that *other* weird noise? *(Softly)* Rumblerumblerumble . . . Sounds like it's coming from her tummy . . . . rumblerumblerumbleRUMBLERUMBLE! . . . Oh, my God, I just remembered! *(Clutching her)* We drank some BEER today! Mama-she's gonna-she's gonna *burp!* RUN FOR YOUR LIVES! BURRRRRRRRRRUP! *(This last is right*

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in her ear. JOANIE falls over, wincing, laughing outright. He laughs too) No *wonder* we're so cranky when we finally get out of there! We've just spent nine months in the Twilight Zone. *(A muffled shout, into her belly)* Don't come out! This is a warning! It's weird out here, tool

JOANIE: *(Laughing)* You'll catch cold, dressed that way. And I need your help out here. *(Pushes him away)* Go put on some more clothes!

BEN: *(A bit irritated)* You're not my mother too, you know.

JOANIE: Get *out* of here! I mean it! *(She rises, props her sketchbook out of the way against a wall)*

BEN: *(He exits through the french doors; but after only a moment sticks his head back in. To the audience)* Don't believe a word she says.

JOANIE: GO!! *(He exits. grinning. She shakes her head, exasperated)* Ben! Ben, Ben, BEN . .

(She takes her smock from the ladder. As she puts it on, she glances at the audience – throughout the rest of this monologue, she is preparing and putting a butterfly stencil on the wall with cans of spray paint)

Our friends ask me why I want another baby when I've already got one. *(Pause)* Somehow that used to sound funnier . . . What's he been *doing* in here, anyway - He promised me he'd spend the whole weekend painting the sky. But, as you can see . . . Mr. Responsibility. *(She crosses to the wall, up right, where she tapes up her stencil)* The irony is, he's gonna make a great father. He really is! . . . I wish you could see him with other people's kids. He'll get down on the floor and hold this serious, top-secret, totally involved conversation with some two-year-old! But, then, if you ask him what on earth they could possibly find to talk about for all that time, he says something like, "Know your enemy." *(works for a moment)* He works in television, [you know].

(Pause. She pours some paint into an aluminum troy, picks up a pair of brushes) (BEN reenters through the kitchen door, now wearing ratty jeans and a corduroy shirt over a T-shirt. He is finishing a sandwich, and also sipping a beer)

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BEN: *(To audience)* Lies, lies, a tissue of lies . . . What? What is it?

JOANIE: I guess you'd have to know sooner or later, Ben. I told them . . . you were in TV.

BEN: *(Horrified)* Oh, God, no. You didn't.

JOANIE: Sorry. Your secret is out.

BEN: *(Kneels)* Friends, I was young, I was a fool. They said I'd meet Miss Piggy. *(To JOANIE, as he rises)* Where do you need me?

JOANIE: Take down the other stencils.

BEN: Check. *(He sets down his beer and sandwich on the windowsill, then starts pulling down stencils. She has begun painting blue sky on the wall)*

BEN: Actually, I'm in television sports *promotion.* Those little teasers that warn you not to miss next Saturday's flaming tapioca plunge?

JOANIE: They're called "promos."

BEN: Well, *that's* what I do. I design those promos. For ten seconds a week I'm a *genius.*

JOANIE: He was a finalist for a Clio Award.

BEN: I lost out to some ex-jock doing a public-service spot on drug abuse. Depressed me so much I got stoned for a week.

JOANIE: *(Irritated)* Why do you *tell* them things like that? You know that's not true.

BEN: Okay. Two days. *(He crosses to dump his handful of stencils by the pile of paint cans at right center)* Joanie's a little paranoid about drugs. She's afraid we did so many of them in college-

JOANIE: *You* did so many!

BEN: ***I*** did so many of them that the baby will be born looking like Flipper. *(A brief but vivid impression)* "Ork! Ork! Ork! Orkin

JOANIE: *(Shocked)* That's not funny! Don't even *think* that! *(Furious)* You go too far

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sometimes, you know that? You think you're *so* hilarious - telling your little dead-baby jokes when our friends come over-

BEN: *(To audience)* I've *never* done that!

JOANIE: Oh, uh-huh! *(Crossing down toward audience)* "How do you make a dead baby float? One scoop of ice cream, and one scoop of dead baby:' How do you think it makes *me* feel when you say things like that? What if something *did* happen? You think it's so funny to joke about now, but what if it *did*?

BEN: *(Still trying to lighten the situation, but it fails)* "Orkl Orkl Orkl" *(Very upset, she pulls her mask over her face to continue painting. Her back to the audience, point-edly ignoring BEN. He looks at the audience helplessly)* Okay, but she's overreacting, too. She really is!... *(Pause)* What if Joanie was right? *(Pause)* What if one of those jokes *did* come true? What if something went wrong with the baby? Would I be able to handle it, or would I panic . . . ?

(Fantasy sequence – transition needs some type of ominous sound/music – can be voiced by Joanie before she rises and turns around ominously. She wears green plastic gloves and stares at BEN over the top of her painting mask. She moves forward into his circle of light)

JOANIE: Benjamin?

BEN: *(Turns, sees her)* Oh, hiya, Dr. Latimer! Did everything come out okay in the delivery room? *(She is silent. He chuckles nervously)* That's a joke! You know- "baby?" "come out?"

JOANIE: My poor dear Benjamin . . .

BEN: *(Growing alarmed)* It's Joanie, isn't it? Something's happened to Joanie!

JOANIE: *(Pulls mask down sadly)* Your wife is fine. I have her under sedation. She-- doesn't know yet.

BEN: Know what? *(Pause)* You mean-the baby? *(She nods)* You mean it's . . . ?

JOANIE: Oh no, no, it's alive! *(Pause)* That is, we definitely *feel* that it's living.

BEN: Why-why do you say "it?" Is it a boy or a girl?

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JOANIE: *(Hesitates)* Yes! . . . Look, why split hairs? I *told* you it was alive.

BEN: *(Shaking her)* WHAT-IS-WRONG-WITH-MYCHILD?!

JOANIE: *(frees herself gently)* Ben, I'm going to level with you. Your - well, let's call him your *son* - *was* born without a body.

BEN: Without a *body?* Oh my God, that's horrible!

JOANIE: *(Sighs)* Yes. Yes, it is. I can only suspect that you or Joanie must have experimented at some point with a marijuana cigarette.

BEN: You mean . . . my boy is nothing but a *head?* That's all there is to him?

JOANIE: I only wish it were that simple, Ben. Your son doesn't even have a head. In fact, he's just an eyeball. I have him right here. *(JOANIE takes a glass eyeball out of her pocket. As BEN rises, she hands it to him)*

BEN: *(Stunned)* This is . . . my son?

JOANIE: Careful how you hold him. He blinks.

BEN: *(Suddenly shrieking)* OH MY GOD, MY SON IS AN EYEBALL! OH MY GOD! WHAT COULD BE WORSE THAN *THIS?!*

JOANIE: *(Whispers)* He's blind!

(BEN screams, tossing the eyeball high into the air. JOANIE catches the eye. Laughing insanely, she returns to her former position. BEN clutches his chest and gasps for breath. JOANIE, instantly back in character, turns from her painting)

JOANIE: Ben . . . ? What's the matter?

BEN: *(Squeaks)* Heart attack! *(She rushes to him, but he avoids her and begins jogging frantically in place, turning in little circles)*

JOANIE: What are you *doing?* Hold still!

BEN: If I stop I'll die! But if I just keep jogging! Then maybe I'll feel like it's just beating fast! Because I'm jogging! And not because I'm having! A heart attack!

JOANIE: *(She finally stops his jogging. He stares at her, panting)* You're having an *anxiety* attack! You've had them before, so we both know there's nothing to be afraid

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of. In a few minutes it'll go away, if you just don't panic. Okay? Focus on me! We're gonna pretend we're in Lamaze class, okay? I want you to take a long, deep breath. *(He nods)* Are you ready? Breathe . . . *innn.* Slow and steady . . . that's it, keep going . . . Good, now *hold* it for a minute. *(Pause)* Okay, now let that air out, but slowwwly . . . and *innn* . . . hold it . . . and *ouuut.* Innnn . . . and ouuut. *Slowwwwly!*

BEN: *(Pause, his breathing has returned to almost normal)* I shouldn't have said what I said about Flipper. I'm sorry. *(She looks at him for a long moment, sighs. She looks at the walls, then back at BEN)*

JOANIE: Do the sun. *(She crosses back to the wall, left, picks up her tray and begins painting areas of sky again)*

BEN: The sun! Riiiight! Jolly or smiling face of the jolly or sun . . . *(Pause)* What color?

JOANIE: Well, what color do you *think?*

BEN: *(Shrugs)* Depends on how much air pollution.

JOANIE: Try yellow.

BEN: Yellow! Now, there's an idea! See, Joanie *knows* about stuff like that, 'cause she's got a B.A. in art. *(He crawls about in search of yellow paint)*

JOANIE: Right now I'm a volunteer assistant at the Met.

BEN: Scared you might finally make some money? *(She gives him a look)* Joke! It's a joke . . . c'mon! *(Both resume working in silence for a moment)*

JOANIE: *(Changing the subject)* Ben and I play this game we call "Tough Questions." You know-sort of a rehearsal. Like, "Daddy, Daddy, why is there death?"

BEN: Or "Mommy, Mommy, what is my thing for?"

JOANIE: Or "How come God makes bag ladies?"

BEN: Or "Who was Leona Helmsley?"

JOANIE: *(Laughs)* All the real biggies we might have to face someday. Okay, Dad, for

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fifty points! I come home from school one day, I'm crying buckets-make believe I'm crying-

BEN: Buckets, right-

JOANIE: I'm fifteen years old, I'm incredibly upset. And I say to you, "Daddy, Daddy, I think I'm gay." And you say-?

BEN: Ah! *(Pause)* Mmm-hmm. *(Pause)* "I don't suppose there's any chance you mean 'convivial'?"

JOANIE: "Dad-dy! Be serious!"

BEN: Right. Sorry. *(Pause)* Umm . . . "Have a seat, my child." *(He motions for Joanie to sit on one of the paint cans at right center. She is a bit reluctant to stop working, but sits as directed, setting her tray down beside her. He looks at her, smiles, gets no response. Then he tries a fatherly little punch on her shoulder)* "Son, listen to me-"

JOANIE: Daughter.

BEN: Daughter? No fair!

JOANIE: *(Firmly)* Daughter, fifteen. Sobbing.

BEN: Why do I always get the worst ones? *(She wails)* Okay, okay! *(Pause. He paces awkwardly, searching for words. Joanie smiles at us, enjoying the game)* "Sweetheart, look - your mother and I - ah, understand what you're going through. Believe me-nobody knows better than we do just how scary and confusing sex can be." (Joanie smacks his leg. He grins) "But hey, this isn't the Dark Ages! After all, we're in the year-" *(Pause)* What year is it?

JOANIE: Well, if I'm fifteen, that would make it . . .

BEN: Christ. *enter year 15 years from this one*. *(Slight pause. They look at each other unhappily)* Sweetheart, we just want you to know . . . to know that no matter what choice you may ultimately make as to your, umm, sexual preference - to know that you'll still be our child . . . and your mother and I will still love you very, very much." *(Pause)* How's that?

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JOANIE: Not bad! But what would you really say?

BEN: *(Shouts)* "Homo! Homo! Homo!" O

(She jumps up, stabbing at him with her paintbrush. He backs away, both of them laughing as he catches the wet blows with his palms. Abruptly he clutches his chest, as if having another of his «heart attacks . . . When she steps toward him anxiously, lowering her paintbrush; he catches her off guard and sweeps her into a hug. They kiss. It is a long embrace, of growing intensity. Finally she becomes self-conscious about the audience. Despite his resistance, she gently but firmly breaks off the kiss. They stand looking out at the audience for a moment, still hugging. Pause. BEN looks at JOANIE)

Parenthood, huh? . . . The Unprepared attempting the Impossible for the sake of the Ungrateful.

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AWARD HISTORY

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